



Saint Columban College
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Redaction Gone Wrong

Redaction gone wrong

Medium Forensics picoCTF 2022

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Description

Now you DONT see me.

This [report](#) has some critical data in it, some of which have been redacted correctly, while some were not. Can you find an important key that was not redacted properly?

Hints

1

22,827 users solved

 86% Liked 

 picoCTF{FLAG}

Submit Flag

Author: The Analyst: Hyposelenia

Challenge: Redaction gone wrong

Category: Forensics

Date: 4/14/26



I. Objective

The goal of this challenge is to **find the hidden flag inside a PDF file**.

At first glance, the flag looks **covered (redacted)**, but the real task is to check if it is *actually hidden* or just *visually covered*.

II. Background

In digital documents like PDFs, **redaction** means hiding sensitive information.

But here's the important part:

! Not all redactions are done properly.

There are two ways to “hide” text:

1. **Fake redaction (bad way)** – putting a black box over text
2. **Real redaction (correct way)** – completely removing the text from the file

Think of it like this:

- Fake redaction = covering words with a marker (you can still erase it and see underneath)
- Real redaction = erasing the words completely

This challenge uses the **bad method**, which means the hidden text is still there—we just need to reveal it.

III. Tool Used

- **PDF Reviewer** - to open and view the document
- **Notepad** - to paste and view extracted text

(Any basic PDF viewer works, no advanced tools needed!)

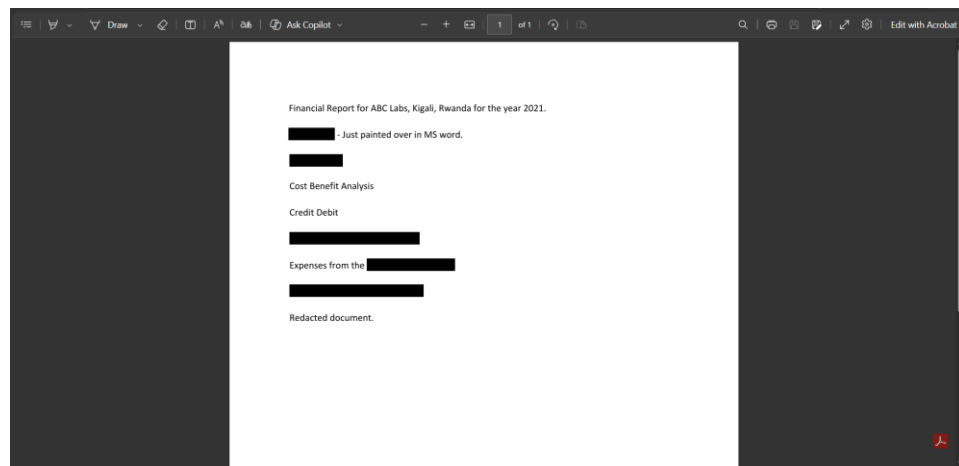


IV. Methodology

1. Downloaded the PDF file from the challenge

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deducted cost

2. Opened the file using a PDF viewer



3. Noticed that some parts of the document were covered with black boxes (redacted text)

Financial Report for ABC Labs, Kigali, Rwanda for the year 2021.

Just painted over in MS word.

Cost Benefit Analysis

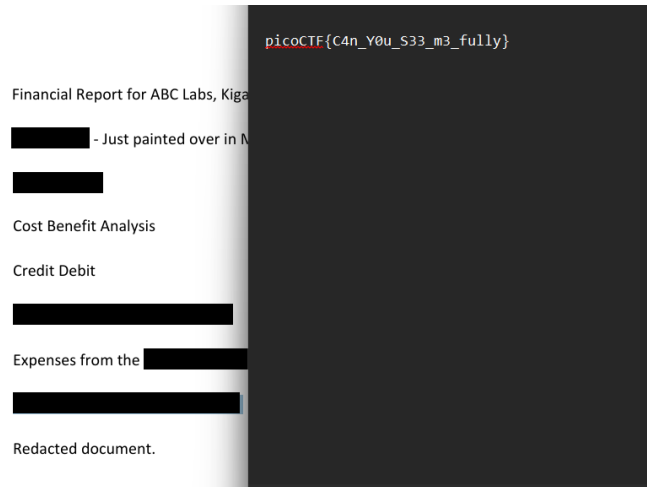
Credit Debit

Expenses from the

Redacted document.



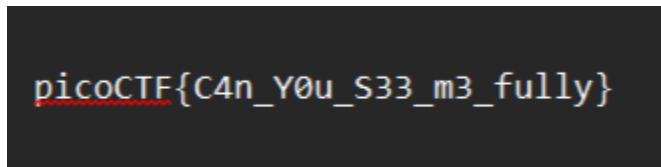
4. Tried selecting/highlighting the blacked-out area
5. Copied the highlighted content
6. Pasted it into Notepad



7. The hidden text appeared—revealing the flag

V. Result

picoCTF{C4n_Y0u_S33_m3_fully}



VI. Explanation

Let's explain this in the simplest way...

The PDF looked like this:

This is a secret: [REDACTED]

But the truth is:

The text was **still there behind the black box**



When we highlighted and copied it, we actually copied:

This is a secret: picoCTF{C4n_Y0u_S33_m3_fully}

The black box only *covered* the text visually—it did NOT remove it.

Key idea:

- The computer still “knows” the hidden text
- The black box is just like putting a sticker over it

So when we copied the text:

- The sticker (black box) was ignored
- The real text underneath was revealed

VII. Conclusion

This challenge teaches an important real-world lesson:

Never trust visual redactions—they might not actually hide anything.

Key takeaways:

- Always check if hidden data is still present
- Copy-paste can reveal “hidden” information
- Simple tools can solve powerful problems

— **The Analyst: Hyposelenia**